Hon'ble Speaker and Hon'ble Members of the Goa Legislative Assembly:

It gives me immense pleasure in welcoming each one of you to the ninth session of the Goa Legislative Assembly.

2. This is my first address to this august House since I took over as the Governor of the State and I am very happy to be in your midst.

3. The State has recently seen a bye-election to the Panaji Constituency due to the vacancy caused by Shri Manohar Parrikar becoming the Defence Minister of India and I take this opportunity to congratulate him and wish him well. I also congratulate Shri Laxmikant Parsekar on becoming the Chief Minister and wish him and my new Council of Ministers well in continuing to take the State forward on the path of progress.

4. Here, I would like to appreciate the people, Government and the State election machinery for

the free, fair and successful conduct of the Assembly bye-poll and Zilla Panchayat elections under the broad guidelines of the Election Commission of India and the State Election Commission with the full cooperation of the various departments.

5. As you all are aware, the socio-economic indicators of the State, as compared to the other States of the country are highly impressive and the State ranks 4th in the country with regard to literacy rate as per the 2011 Census and has the highest per capita income.

6. **Honorable Members**, Goa is an example of harmony and tranquility and my Government believes in strengthening the bonds of amity through peaceful resolution of disputes and differences through dialogue and discussions.

7. Attempts by any group or section to disturb the peace and tranquility by means other than democratic, shall be met with full force of law.

8. To enable the law enforcement agency to effectively discharge their duties, my Government has made all efforts to enhance the capabilities of Goa Police by augmenting infrastructure and through modernization of police force.

9. I take great satisfaction in mentioning that while effectively keeping the law and order situation in control in the State, the Government has also paid extra attention on issues relating to security and safety of women in Goa.

10. Further, in order to keep up the morale of the police force, my Government is taking up several measures for welfare of members of the police force.

11. My Government has committed to the ideology of “Zero Tolerance to Corruption” and has used Information Technology extensively in bringing transparency through E-tendering, electronic clearance and strengthening of

departmental as well as the State vigilance and anti-corruption mechanism.

12. Information Technology will be further leveraged to achieve our objectives of good governance in all spheres by bringing in transparency in Government functioning and improving the efficiency of the public systems. The new Information Technology policy of my Government will reflect the high priority my Government accords to E-Governance and giving a fillip to the economy through Information Technology services and related employment creation.

13. As the Hon'ble Members are aware, the State having successfully countered the global economic slowdown of the recent years was pushed into a tight financial phase due to stoppage of mining in the State resulting from Hon'ble Supreme Court orders.

14. The situation was compounded by the fact that my Government had taken over the reigns of the State at a time when the financial health was stressed and debt liabilities were on the rise.

15. However, with prudent fiscal management, the Government has been successful in ensuring that the State continued on the path of progress and prioritized social sector spending for the benefit of the people.

16. As you are aware, the ban on mining by Hon'ble Supreme Court, had put a severe strain on revenues of the State apart from affecting the livelihood of close to 1.50 lakh (one lakh fifty thousand) people dependent on mining sector, directly or indirectly, and caused a tremendous loss of around 20 percent of the Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP). With the mining sector, which contributed immensely to the economy in terms of income and employment generation, coming to a stand-still, the State's exchequer was badly affected, limiting our spending capacities.

17. However, while maintaining fiscal prudence, my Government continued with the implementation of social sector schemes as well as creation of capital assets to provide the much-needed fillip to the economy of the State. The increase in growth rate of Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) at constant prices from 4.17 percent in 2012-13 to 7.71 percent in 2013-14 is the testimony to the Government's efforts and resolve.

18. My Government rose to the challenge of managing the State's finances through various innovative measures to fill the revenue gap and also took various measures to provide respite to those affected.

19. The umbrella scheme : "Welfare of mining affected people" was previously launched by my Government to provide financial relief to those affected and people engaged in various employments related to mining activities directly or indirectly.

20. In addition, through continual implementation of other flagship schemes like Dayanand Social Security Scheme, Laadli Laxmi and Griha Aadhar, extra focus was given to the mining affected areas, for socio-economic aid in the time of difficulty.

21. The lender banks were also asked to re-schedule the loans and adopt a go-slow approach until the mining resumed. A new scheme : “Debt relief scheme for mining affected borrowers of financial institutions” was notified in November, 2014 to provide financial relief to the borrowers.

22. My Government has taken up the issue of revoking the mining suspension order issued in September, 2012, very strongly and I am sure that with the considered intervention of the present Central Government in revoking the suspension order, mining activity would be restored very soon, as per the capping limits prescribed by the Hon’ble Supreme Court.

23. My Government is also making all efforts to get the current cap revised by the Hon'ble Supreme Court and would ensure regulation of mining activity keeping in view the social, ecological and environmental factors.

24. As directed by the Hon'ble Supreme Court of India, my Government has conducted five e-auctions of the mineral ore stacks lying in the State under the supervision of the Monitoring Committee of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in 2014 which augmented State revenues substantially.

25. Likewise, under the directions of the Hon'ble Supreme Court, my Government has issued notification formulating the scheme viz. "Goa Mineral Ore Permanent Fund Scheme" for creation of a permanent fund for protection of inter-generational equity by reserving 10 percent of the sale proceeds out of the e-auction and 10 percent of future sale / export price of iron ore from the State of Goa.

26. My Government has further formulated “The Goa Grant of Mining Leases Policy, 2014” and notified vide Notification dated January 20, 2015, in accordance with Government’s policy decision, Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act and Rules made thereunder.

27. My Government will continue to undertake necessary measures to see that the mining industry is re-booted and achieves its full potential in order to strengthen the State’s economy and support the livelihood of the people dependent on this important sector.

28. **Hon’ble Members**, the State is presently under the Value Added Tax (VAT) system and is gearing up in all respects for the proposed new taxation system of “Goods and Services Tax” (GST), which would be a significant reform milestone in the history of the country.

29. My Government has already taken steps to facilitate faster and prompt payment through the

facility of online payment of tax including interest and penalty, which would be of great benefit to the traders.

30. In order to further encourage industrial growth in Goa, my Government has granted additional period of one year tax exemption benefit in addition/in continuation to what has been granted to them under the Goa Value Added Tax deferment – cum – Net Present Value Compulsory Payment (Sixth Amendment) Scheme, 2014.

31. My Government is aware that, due to lack of a robust and responsive institutional frame-work for industrial development, the growth under industrial sector has not been very impressive previously.

32. Therefore, in order to kick-start investments under the manufacturing sector by encouraging and facilitating investors in Goa, my Government has brought in the Goa Investment Policy-2014,

that seeks, among other things, to create 50,000 (fifty thousand) jobs and facilitate Rupees 25,000 (twenty five thousand) crores of new investments in the next five years.

33. The policy seeks to promote investments aimed at employment creation and income generation in the State, particularly in thrust areas like knowledge-based Industry, Financial Services, Pharmaceuticals and Bio-technology, Tourism, Aviation, Aerospace and Defence, Information Technology Hardware and Electronics and Agro-based and Food Processing Industries.

34. My Government aims to provide high quality infrastructure to industries, high quality power supply and use innovative and socio-economically acceptable mechanisms to make land available for industrial development through the aegis of the Investment Promotion Board.

35. **Hon'ble Members**, I am very happy to state that my Government has successfully

implemented the Unique Identification (UID) project in the State with near 100 percent coverage of its population. Now, the process of seeding Aadhaar Numbers into the database of beneficiaries of all Government schemes is being implemented, with about 70 percent of Liquid Petroleum Gas (LPG) consumers having been linked with Aadhaar.

36. Since Goa was the first State to initiate direct transfer of assistance to beneficiary accounts, it will be our endeavour to achieve 100 percent target by the end of this financial year for all schemes.

37. My Government has implemented the “Atal Gram Yojana (AGY)” scheme under the aegis of the State Planning Board in Netravali village of Sanguem taluka, wherein a number of innovative initiatives have been implemented with exemplary success, in order to encourage and inculcate entrepreneurship qualities among the rural people of the village to raise their economic status and to

replicate this success, a separate body is being registered under the Societies Registration Act to carry forward the good work.

38. My Government has successfully conducted the Sixth Economic Census (2012-13) under the aegis of the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, Government of India, New Delhi and it is a matter of satisfaction that Goa is amongst the States who have completed the work within the stipulated time period.

39. My Government has also brought out a publication “Welfare Schemes 2014” in English for the benefit of the general public. The Konkani and Marathi versions of this publication are being printed and will be made available shortly.

40. **Hon’ble Members**, it has been the endeavour of my Government to revive and rejuvenate the agriculture and allied sectors through innovative steps to promote agriculture through farm mechanization, enhanced support

and adoption of knowledge-based approach towards training of farmers. It shall be the endeavour of my Government to further popularize agriculture and allied activities of Horticulture, Floriculture and Olericulture or vegetable gardening.

41. As many as 25 villages across the State have been selected under Village Level Agricultural Development Plan and, in order to provide hassle-free and prompt services to the farming community, the Government has set up two District Offices, one in Margao, South Goa, and the other at Tonca, Caranzalem, North Goa. The subsidy claims of the farmers will be sanctioned and disbursed by these offices.

42. Under the fisheries sector, various new initiatives towards rearing of high-value fish in open sea cages have been taken, and I am happy that the total fish production during the year 2014 is significantly higher than that of 2013.

43. In order to provide training to the youth from the fishermen community regarding the techniques of fishing and use of navigational aids properly, a dedicated training vessel at a cost of Rupees 1.18 crore (One crore eighteen lakhs) has been built.

44. Animal Husbandry sector has similarly seen greater growth. To ensure that the Kamdhenu (Sudharit) Scheme achieves the objective of increasing the milk production, my Government has ensured that the “Cattle Melas” are held on regular basis, so as to facilitate farmers to purchase the animals of their choice within the State itself, so that precious money and energy of the farmers is saved. The farmers have been provided with an incentive on each litre of milk supplied by them to the co-operative dairy society.

45. Further, one hundred and seventy three milk dairy societies have been provided assistance for procuring of automated milk collection systems and

three veterinary Key Village Sub-centres have been upgraded to Veterinary Dispensaries.

46. **Hon'ble Members**, the latest report by the Forest Survey of India states that the total tree cover of Goa is 65 percent and my Government has been making consistent efforts for maintaining greenery in the State. During the current year, an area of 33.75 hectares has been covered under plantation by planting over three lakh seedlings of different species.

47. Two patrolling stations have been set up and brought into use at Mhadei Wildlife Sanctuary and Bhagwan Mahaveer National Park for the strengthening of forest combing operations.

48. Improving infrastructure in Village Panchayats through development works is a priority with my Government, and it has released Rupees 7.00 crores (seven crores) to Village Panchayats and Rupees 5.00 crores (five crores) to Zilla

Panchayats for construction of roads, bridges, pathways with pavers and community halls.

49. Under Deendayal Infrastructure Development Scheme 2013, the proposals submitted by forty-four Panchayats have been approved for the development of major infrastructure projects submitted by them.

50. As Hon'ble Members are aware, the State has witnessed the visit of more than 50 lakh persons of all faiths from India and abroad to take a glimpse of Saint Francis Xavier during the six-week Exposition which provided an occasion to experience God's grace and strengthen faith for many during the period from 22nd November, 2014 to 4th January, 2015.

51. This mega global event was concluded successfully with the dedicated efforts of the Exposition Secretariat created for the purpose by the Government and all the dedicated volunteers together with cooperation of all the pilgrims.

52. The International Film Festival of India (IFFI) is another event held in Goa by my Government in co-ordination with the Directorate of Film Festival and Union Ministry of Information and Broadcasting.

53. Goa is now a permanent venue for hosting this annual international event of repute and the problems faced earlier have been overcome with the tremendous improvements seen in the organization of this event.

54. **Hon'ble Members**, Goa undoubtedly is one of the most important and sought after tourist destinations for both international and domestic tourists. Globally, people prioritize Goa as a favoured destination and my Government has embarked on diversification of tourism activities and enabling infrastructure, so that tourist retention as well as arrivals are enhanced.

55. My Government initiated an exclusive Women Taxi service for comfort of tourists in

addition to the efforts made to provide Lifeguarding and Water Patrol services on the beaches of Goa, which altogether rescued nearly 444 lives in the year 2014-15. We are in the process of launching new tourism services and products, such as hot air ballooning, heli-tourism, sea-plane services, adventure sports, amphibian vessels, river rafting at Mhadei and Tillari rivers.

56. My Government has also initiated activities like Segway tours, Luxury Yacht services, Water-based activity, Entertainment-cum-Water sports Park at Sea, Hop-on-Hop-off bus services, Horse trails - introduction of nature sight-seeing trails on horsebacks, All Terrain vehicles (ATVs) for travelling or adventure over short stretches, Hovercrafts and Motorized paragliding.

57. My Government has created a number of employment and business opportunities for the locals to earn their livelihood through tourism, by issuing permissions for erection of temporary shacks on the beaches frequented by tourists.

58. Likewise, residents are also encouraged to make investment in tourism sector and No Objection Certificates are issued to interested people for erection of tents and huts in their private properties, to enhance accommodation facilities for the budget tourists.

59. Several key tourism infrastructure projects like beautification of areas around major tourist spots, completion of Panjim jetty, mega tourism circuit development at Calangute, Candolim, Sangolda and Anjuna were undertaken to improve the facilities for the tourists and carrying capacity of the State.

60. My Government has finalized a policy for regulating water sports in the State and has decided to implement a single window system for all water sports operators and airport taxis through Goa Tourism Development Corporation (GTDC) in order to ensure transparency and fairness in operations of the water sports and taxi operators.

61. **Hon'ble Members**, Goa has excellent health parameters as compared to other States of the country and which are much ahead of the national averages. Even so, my Government is in the process of further upgrading and renovating its health infrastructure and services for increasing accessibility and quality of health care.

62. Under the Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme, my Government reacted swiftly in setting up the preparedness and response mechanism to the threat posed by the Ebola outbreak in West Africa and took all possible precautions in close coordination with the Central Government with weekly monitoring of the situation.

63. Similarly, the response to the emergent situation caused by Influenza A (H1N1) Flu was prompt with measures taken for detection, treatment and containment, including immediate stocking of medicines and protective equipment, creating awareness and training of health workers.

64. To provide state-of-the-art super-specialty health care, my Government started the cardio vascular and thoracic surgery unit at Goa Medical College with effect from April, 2014. This measure has provided immense relief to patients who otherwise had to obtain cardiac treatment from outside the State.

65. I am happy that the first cardiac surgery was performed in the hospital in April, 2014 and bypass surgeries, valve replacement surgeries for congenital heart diseases, thoracic surgeries and fistula surgeries are now being conducted for the first time in Goa Medical College.

66. Under the Renal Transplant programme, renal transplants are being carried out at Goa Medical College.

67. In addition to these steps, I am glad to note that my Government is implementing a “Mediclaim Scheme” for economically weaker sections for

treatment of major aliments like cardio-vascular diseases, kidney transplants, cancer and neuro-surgery.

68. To provide for additional infrastructure to meet Medical Council of India (MCI) norms for 150 under-graduate medical seats programme, which is now completing the third academic year, new buildings are being constructed for the girls hostel, lecture halls and examination hall-cum-auditorium, within the Goa Medical College complex, and the same will be dedicated to the State soon.

69. The Goa College of Pharmacy has also been recognized by the Goa University as a Ph.D. Centre and steps are being taken to upgrade the college as a centre of excellence, so as to promote research activities.

70. **Hon'ble Members, t**he strong concern and commitment of my Government to social welfare is reflected in the number of schemes being implemented for various sections of the society.

71. A number of schemes are being implemented for our differently-abled residents and a scheme for purchase of aids and appliances for such persons has been notified in November, 2014.

72. Stipends and scholarships are also provided to differently-abled persons to pursue their education, wherein in the current year, 111 (one hundred and eleven) students have been benefitted. Under the Scheme “Awards for marriage with Disabled Persons”, 12 couples were presented awards.

73. Under the scheme, “Financial Assistance to Persons with Severe Disabilities”, 76 persons were provided assistance, while 6 voluntary organizations have been provided a one-time grant for setting up of Physiotherapy Centres. Further, Braille Libraries are being set up for visually-impaired persons.

74. The State has provided the best social security cover for its weaker and disadvantaged sections, including senior citizens, widows, children and adults, differently-abled persons, orphan children, Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, minority communities, people living with HIV / AIDS and the physically and mentally-challenged citizens. Under the Dayanand Social Security Scheme, financial assistance was given to 1,33,034 (one lakh thirty three thousand and thirty four) beneficiaries.

75. Besides the above, a host of other schemes like, Rajiv Awas Yojana, Antya Sanskar Sahay Yojana, Stipend and Scholarships, Special homes for physically and mentally-challenged people, Day Care schemes for senior citizens, financial assistance to traditional occupations and Self Help Groups are also under implementation.

76. **Hon'ble Members,** my Government has recently notified a scheme for grant of

compensation to the operational staff of Fire and Emergency Services for any loss of life or suffer full or partial disability in the course of performance of their bonafide official duties.

77. I am happy that awareness of dealing with emergencies was addressed through a Training of Trainers' programme for teachers in "Basic Fire Safety and Evacuation Drill" from all the schools in the State of Goa, and a Training Programme on "Disaster Preparedness and Fire Safety Training Campaign" initiated at Village Panchayat level.

78. My Government has worked effectively in the area of protecting and advancing the interests of deserving employees and workmen with the Enforcement Cell of Labour Department having carried out 2,440 (two thousand four hundred and forty) inspections and securing convictions against 19 defaulters under various labour laws during the period from April, 2014 to December, 2014.

79. The Goa Building and Other Construction Workers Welfare Board collects one percent cess on the total cost of construction as contribution from employers and the amount so collected is then utilized for the welfare schemes of the building workers.

80. The Goa Labour Welfare Board also provides monetary benefits to industrial workers in the State of Goa through 17 welfare schemes for giving financial assistance to purchase spectacles to the industrial workers, scheme for providing maternity benefits to the female workers, a scheme for mentally-challenged children of industrial workers, and award of scholarships to school or college-going children of industrial employees.

81. **Hon'ble Members,** my Government has taken adequate steps towards promoting social and economic empowerment of women through various programmes, mainstreaming gender

concerns, creating awareness about their rights and facilitating institutional and legislative support for enabling them to realize their human rights and develop their full potential.

82. My Government is committed to the Hon'ble Prime Minister's "Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao" scheme to cherish and nurture girl child, including steps to help improve the adverse child sex ratio in the country. I am glad to note that, in Goa, firm steps in this direction have already been taken since past couple of years.

83. The Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques Act (PC-PNDT) was effectively enforced in the State to check the decline in female sex ratio. Further, the Laadli Laxmi Scheme, which was launched in the State in July 2012, also seeks to address this issue. Since inception of the scheme, 21,834 (twenty one thousand eight hundred and thirty four) girls have been provided assistance of Rupees one lakh each.

84. The innovative Griha Aadhar scheme, which was launched in October 2012, to provide financial relief to economically-weaker section to tide over rising inflation, is still continued, wherein an amount of Rupees 1,200 (one thousand two hundred) per month is provided to women from economically-weaker families.

85. During the current year, around 18,109 (eighteen thousand one hundred and nine) new families have been brought under the scheme, taking the total number of families receiving assistance to 1,20,033 (one lakh twenty thousand thirty three) as in February, 2015.

86. **Hon'ble Members,** my Government realizes the need for quality education to bring about overall development of the student community who are the future citizens of the State.

87. Therefore, having almost achieved universalization of elementary education, the thrust

of my Government is to improve the quality of education, at all levels, by introducing modern e-learning and teaching aids in its educational institutions and to provide a better schooling environment for the students.

88. To improve quality of e-content, schools, colleges and the Goa University are being provided with Wi-Fi or hotspots and the Laptop-e scheme will benefit around 18,000 (eighteen thousand) students in the current academic year.

89. In order to arrest dropouts and motivate students to continue further studies, the ongoing "Goa Scholars Scheme" has been continued, wherein 19 students have been selected as Goa scholars, out of which 14 are studying abroad and 5 students are studying within the country. In addition, under the Rajiv Gandhi Meritorious Scholarship scheme, 1,691 (one thousand six hundred ninety one) students studying in Classes X and XII would be benefitted.

90. Under the Mid-Day Meal Scheme, my Government has taken all necessary measures to see that nutritious and healthy food is provided to the school children as per the choice of the parents and students, and at present, 111 (one hundred eleven) Self Help Groups, Mahila Mandals and 5 Parent-Teacher Associations are supplying Mid-Day Meals.

91. It gives me pleasure to announce our singular achievement that 100 percent Government and Government-aided schools in Goa have 100 percent trained teachers in place.

92. Keeping the present and future needs of trained teachers, and to attract youth to join this noble profession, my Government has already approved the creation of a new District Institute of Education and Training (DIET) in South Goa for running Diploma in Education course for students and various refresher training courses for in-service teachers.

93. **Hon'ble Members,** it is a matter of great satisfaction that majority of schools in Goa have toilets. However, we are committed to further increase the number of toilets in proportion to the strength of the students in schools, and it gives me pleasure to announce that my Government is committed to provide one toilet independently for girls in 100 percent schools in Goa, as a part of the major and significant Swachh Bharat initiative of the Hon'ble Prime Minister, Shri Narendra Modi.

94. The construction of the state-of-the-art project for solid waste management has been taken up at Saligao in North Goa, based on mechanical and biological treatment processes with proper segregation, recovery of re-cyclables and bio-methanation technology as a further strategy to align ourselves with the national movement of Swachh Bharat and realize our vision of a clean Goa.

95. Recognizing that infrastructure development is the key to faster economic growth, my Government has been making all possible efforts to build the required infrastructure to provide the much-needed push to the growth momentum.

96. My Government has embarked on the project of construction of “New Mandovi Bridge” across river Mandovi at Panaji, to ease traffic congestion due to intersection of national highways and further improve connectivity. Construction of a new six-lane bridge across river Zuari with assistance from Government of India is also being taken up.

97. **Hon’ble Members**, my Government is very keen on continuing with efforts to place the State on to a faster growth track and inclusive development of all concerned with the active support and co-operation of all stakeholders, in keeping with the call of our Hon’ble Prime Minister of ensuring “Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas”.

98. I conclude by wishing you all a fruitful and productive session ahead.

JAI HIND, JAI GOA